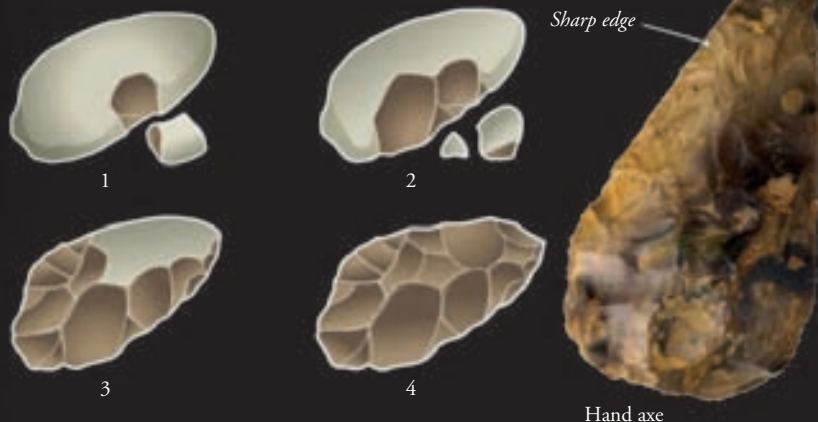




Multipurpose tool

Homo erectus's favourite tool was something called a hand axe. It was made by chipping flakes off a stone (using a heavier rock as a hammer) to make sharp edges on the sides. It was used for all sorts of jobs, from skinning and butchering animals to smashing bones (to release the marrow), and digging for deep roots. Such tools made it much easier for *Homo erectus* to eat meat.

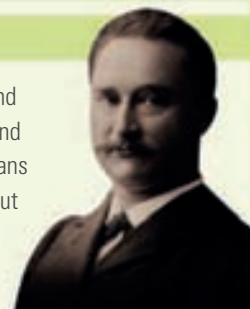
Making fire

Could *Homo erectus* make fire? Scientists don't know for sure. Patches of ash in caves inhabited by *Homo erectus* 400,000 years ago hint that the species could create fire, but the ash might be from wild fires. The mastery of fire was an important step in human history. It allowed our ancestors to cook, making food safer to eat and easier to digest. Fire can also be used to scare predators away, and it provided vital warmth as early humans spread to cold parts of the world.



DID YOU KNOW...?

In 1891, Eugene Dubois, a Dutch scientist, found the first known *Homo erectus* fossil on the island of Java in Indonesia. Dubois thought that humans evolved from apes in Asia rather than Africa, but later discoveries of *Australopithecus* fossils in Africa proved him wrong.



MAMMALS



Thick ridge of bone across brow

Long, low skull

Brain size

Fossilized skulls reveal that *Homo erectus*'s brain was at least twice the size of that of *Australopithecus*, though only 70 per cent as big as a modern human's. Some scientists think the larger brain allowed *Homo erectus* to use language and to live in complex social groups.



Large jaws and teeth